

A Register of Reconstructions

What the evidence shows, what Falkener supplies, and what is known now — for each of the three games.

Falkener's rules are not in the ancient sources. They are his, inferred from what survives, and the book presents them in the imperative with worked example games. This register separates the three layers for each game: what the evidence shows, what Falkener supplies, and what is known now.

It is not a correction. His reconstructions are careful, they produce playable games, and in 1892 nobody had tried. It is a reader's instrument, because the book itself does not mark where one layer ends and the next begins.

One thing this register does not do is score him. Reconstructing a lost game from a board and a handful of verses is legitimate scholarship, it is still how the subject proceeds, and the modern reconstructions rest on the same absence he was working in. What has changed since 1892 is not the evidence but the convention: a reconstruction is now published as one, with its assumptions on the page. Falkener published his as rules. The difference is presentational, and it is the only thing standing between this book and a modern one.

Tau, or the Game of Robbers (with the Roman *ludus latrunculorum*) · section IV

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

Boards and men survive, and tomb paintings show the game in play. How far back they go is itself contested inside this volume: Falkener writes of the fourth dynasty, while Birch's paper — printed in section II — dates the tomb of Rashepses, where he found the clearest scene, to the fifth. The earlier date is Falkener's, not the evidence's. The hieroglyphic name is read *sent*, written without a determinative and — Birch's own word — *very ambiguous*. On the Roman side, Latin poets refer to the *latrunculi*, the little robbers, and to pieces being blocked or surrounded.

WHAT FALKENER SUPPLIES

A complete ruleset: how pieces enter, how they move, how capture works by surrounding, and how the game is decided — followed by a full sample game in move notation played to a finish. He also identifies the Roman game as the Egyptian one carried west.

WHAT IS KNOWN NOW

The Egyptian game shown in those tomb scenes — a board of three rows of ten, with a handful of men a side — is what is now called **senet**, and its rules are still not known. Falkener's own board is not that board: he reasons his way to twelve squares each way and thirty men a side, and no surviving Egyptian board is anything like it. So the modern identification attaches to the evidence in section II, not to the game he builds here. Every published set, Falkener's included, is a reconstruction assembled from fragments spanning more than a thousand years of play that will have changed over them. The identification of the Roman game with the Egyptian is not what specialists hold today; *latrunculi* is treated as its own game.

Senat, and Seega beside it · section V

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

A different and smaller board: five squares each way, twenty-five cells, and Falkener gives the same game on seven and nine squares a side. It is not the 144-cell board of section IV with fewer men on it — it is another game, which the section's own printed heading sets out plainly: *Senat, the ancient Egyptian game. Seega, the modern Egyptian game*. For the modern half the evidence is **E. W. Lane's** account of the Egyptian fellaheen, published in *Manners and Customs of the Modern Egyptians* (1836), which Falkener reprints and credits: players scooping holes in the ground and using stones, beads or beans for men, which they call *kelbs*, dogs. Falkener did not see this himself. He never visited Egypt for it; he read Lane, and says so twice.

WHAT FALKENER SUPPLIES

The identification of Lane's living Seega with the ancient game shown on the monuments, and a ruleset for the ancient one: entry, movement, and capture by immediate successive takes. With it, the argument that a quick game must have existed alongside the long one, because ordinary people do not play long games.

WHAT IS KNOWN NOW

Seega's rules are not in doubt — Lane recorded them from living players, and H. Carrington Bolton described the game again in *The Field* in 1889. This is the one game in the volume whose rules are actually known, and knowing them is what makes the rest of the chapter a reconstruction rather than a record: what is inferred is that the ancient game on the monuments is the same game. Capture by successive takes is the modern draughts convention, and its appearance in the ancient rules is Falkener's, not Egypt's. The continuity he notices in the word *kelbs* is a real observation and worth keeping, though not the etymology he hangs on it: Arabic *kalb* and Greek *κύων* are unrelated words that happen to mean the same animal, and what they share is the habit of calling gaming-pieces dogs, not a common root.

Hab em Han, the Game of the Bowl · section VI

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

A round board with a vessel at the centre, shown in tomb scenes with spectators around it. Falkener calls it *a circular board, having a bowl in the middle*, and Birch says the pieces *moved on concentric circles*. Concentric circles and a spiral are not the same figure, and the difference matters here: mehen, which this game is now identified with, has a board in the form of a coiled snake — one continuous spiral track, not a set of separate rings. Whether the two men were describing a spiral imperfectly or a genuinely different board cannot be settled from what they print. Birch read the name

over it as *hab em han*, the game of the jar. Falkener notes the board's resemblance to the circular labyrinth on the coins of Gnosus.

WHAT FALKENER SUPPLIES

Pieces enter two at a time by the throw of astragals; the bowl holds the stakes and the pieces that reach home; the winner is decided by how many pieces are brought home rather than by finishing first. He states plainly that *as it was a game for money, it was evidently played with dice*.

WHAT IS KNOWN NOW

This is the game modern Egyptology calls **mehen**, the coiled one, named for the serpent deity who encircles the sun god; it belongs to the Predynastic period and the Old Kingdom. Its rules are not known either. The best evidence is a scene in the tomb of Hesre at Saqqara showing the pieces that went with the board — lions, lionesses and sets of marbles — which is more than Falkener had and still not a ruleset.